

Samfya Town Council Development Records Dataset

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Abstract

This data article describes a curated dataset of development and council records for Samfya Town Council and Bangweulu Constituency in Luapula Province, Zambia. The dataset contains three pipe separated CSV files: 28 Constituency Development Fund project and activity records, 90 council-resource records, and 21 council-news records. Records were collected from publicly available Samfya Town Council webpages, linked publications, council minutes, budget documents, Integrated Development Plan materials, and news posts. The cleaned files preserve source URLs and retrieval information, standardise council and ward names, normalise dates, map project-status terms to a controlled vocabulary, and retain both original and parsed monetary values where amounts were available. The public dataset is hosted on Kaggle, and the scraping and cleaning code are available in the accompanying GitHub repository.

Specifications Table

Item	Description
Subject	Data mining, local government data, and public administration
Specific subject area	Council records, Constituency Development Fund projects, public resources, and council news
Type of data	Tabular data in CSV files; text and URL metadata
How data were acquired	Automated web scraping of public Samfya Town Council webpages, linked documents, and paginated news posts; structured extraction from public council records
Data format	Raw and cleaned pipe separated CSV files in UTF-8 encoding
Parameters for data collection	Publicly accessible Samfya Town Council pages and documents relevant to CDF projects, budgets, minutes, plans, reports, council resources, and news
Description of data collection	The scraper discovered public council documents and news entries, retained source links and retrieval dates, and produced raw handoff files. The cleaning pipeline standardised text and selected fields while retaining raw values for traceability.
Data source location	Samfya Town Council, Samfya District, Luapula Province, Zambia
Data accessibility	Publicly available on Kaggle: https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/giftkanene/samfya-council-development-records . Code and documentation: https://github.com/Giftkanene/group36-data-mining-project

Value of the Data

- The data provide a structured view of CDF projects, council publications, and public news from one Zambian local authority.
- Source URLs and retrieval information allow users to trace records back to official council webpages and linked documents.
- The files can support local development monitoring, document discovery, transparency analysis, and exploratory analysis of CDF activities and council communications.
- The pipe separated files and accompanying code provide a reproducible starting point for extending the dataset with future council records.

Data Description

The Kaggle dataset contains three cleaned files. Each record has a stable identifier and retains source provenance. The CDF file combines named projects and funding activities, using the record_kind field to distinguish the two forms of evidence. The council-resource file indexes publications and other documents available through the council website. The news file contains published council articles and available article text.

Table 1. Files in the Samfya Town Council Development and Council Records dataset.

File	Records	Columns	Content
db-unza26-csc4792-samfya_cdf_projects.csv	28	30	CDF projects and activities, statuses, wards, years, amounts, and source URLs
db-unza26-csc4792-samfya_council_resources.csv	90	17	Council documents and resources, including titles, categories, years, file types, and URLs
db-unza26-csc4792-samfya_news.csv	21	20	Council news articles, publication dates, article text, mentioned amounts, and URLs

The CDF project table includes council and constituency fields, ward, project name, project status, year, funding source, monetary values where reported, and source information. Original fields remain alongside cleaned fields to preserve the relationship between the published record and the standardised value. The resource table records document titles, categories, years, direct document URLs, source-page URLs, file types, and retrieval timestamps. The news table includes article titles, published dates, excerpts, available article text, linked document URLs, and the first identified monetary amount when present in the text.

Experimental Design Materials and Methods

Data collection

Data were collected from the official Samfya Town Council website and linked public documents. The scraping workflow used a descriptive user agent, request timeouts, retries, deduplication, and a low request rate. It targeted community-project pages, grants and loans pages, skills and bursaries pages, council publications, and paginated news. The document-discovery process indexed public links to materials such as minute books, budgets, financial statements, Integrated Development Plan documents, project lists, and engagement reports. Where an official council HTTPS certificate could not be verified, the workflow recorded the limitation and used a narrowly scoped fallback for that public, non-authenticated source.

Data processing

Raw files were read as UTF-8 pipe separated text and were not modified in place. The cleaning pipeline trimmed and normalised whitespace, standardised the council name to Samfya Town Council, standardised known ward names, and mapped project-status phrases to Completed, In progress, Under procurement, Deferred, Proposed, or Unknown. Monetary text was retained in the original field and parsed into numeric Zambian Kwacha values only where the text was unambiguous. Years were extracted into four digit fields, dates were normalised to ISO format, and exact duplicate rows were removed. Missing values remain blank when the source did not provide the information.

Data validation

Validation checks confirmed that the cleaned files contain a single header row, use the pipe character as the delimiter, contain no exported index column, and include at least one data row. The final files contain 28 CDF records with 30 columns, 90 council-resource records with 17 columns, and 21 news records with 20 columns. The cleaned CDF, resource, and news records retain their relevant source URLs.

Limitations

The dataset represents material available through public council webpages and linked documents at the time of collection. Some source records do not state a project status or amount, and those values are retained as Unknown or blank rather than inferred. Monetary values reported in narrative news text may describe allocations, budgets, or other amounts; the preserved source text should be consulted before aggregation. Website content and linked documents may change after collection.

Ethics Statement

The dataset was compiled from publicly accessible council webpages and documents. It does not collect survey responses, medical records, or other private personal data. Source URLs are retained to support attribution and verification.

CRedit Authorship Contribution Statement

Gift Kanene: project coordination, web scraping, software, data curation, and repository coordination. Khadijah Zimba: support for data collection and submission coordination. Ben Samuel: data cleaning, validation, and documentation. Mwansa Matanda: Kaggle dataset description and publication coordination. Lusungu Mulenga: data-description manuscript preparation.

Data Availability

Samfya Council Development Records [Data set]. Kaggle.
<https://www.kaggle.com/datasets/giftkanene/samfya-council-development-records>

References

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- [4] Republic of Zambia, Ministry of Local Government and Rural Development, Local Government Act No. 2 of 2019, 2019. <https://zambialii.org/akn/zm/act/2019/2/eng@2019-04-11>.